



Creatine: What Is It and Why Are So Many People Talking About It?

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(*“Wait a minute... isn’t that just for bodybuilders?” You may ask. 😊*) Not exactly. Creatine is one of the most researched supplements in the world and is gaining attention not only in athletics, but also in healthy aging, muscle preservation, balance, brain health, and recovery. In fact, our bodies naturally make creatine every day. It is produced primarily in the liver, kidneys, and pancreas from amino acids including glycine, arginine, and methionine. [1,2] Creatine is then stored mostly in the muscles, where it helps produce quick cellular energy known as ATP (adenosine triphosphate). Think of ATP as the body’s “energy currency” used during movement, strength, balance reactions, and muscle contraction.

We also obtain small amounts of creatine from foods such as red meat and fish. However, aging adults — especially women — often consume less dietary creatine and gradually lose muscle mass over time. This age-related muscle loss (called sarcopenia) may contribute to weakness, slower mobility, poor balance, frailty, and increased fall risk. [1,3]

So, What Does Creatine Actually Do?

Creatine helps muscles produce energy more efficiently during activity. Research suggests it may help support:

- muscle strength,
- exercise performance,
- recovery,
- lean muscle mass,
- and possibly even cognitive and neurologic health in aging adults. [1,3]

For older adults, creatine is increasingly being studied alongside resistance training because maintaining muscle is critically important for:

- balance,
- posture,
- bone support,
- blood sugar regulation,
- mobility,
- and independence as we age.

(In other words, strong muscles help keep us upright, steady, and able to haul groceries without sounding like a bowl of Rice Krispies getting out of the car.)

But What About the Liver?

Since your body naturally makes creatine in the liver, many people wonder whether taking supplemental creatine could somehow “overwork” or damage the liver. Current research in healthy individuals does not show that standard doses of creatine monohydrate cause liver



damage. [1,4] In fact, the liver already participates in creatine production naturally every day. Most clinical studies using recommended doses — typically around 3–5 grams daily — have not demonstrated harmful effects on liver function in healthy adults. [1,4]

That said, there are a few important cautions:

- People with existing liver disease or kidney disease should speak with a qualified healthcare practitioner before using creatine.
- Excessive doses, dehydration, poor-quality supplements, anabolic steroid use, or combining multiple bodybuilding products may increase risk.
- Some isolated case reports of liver stress exist, but these are relatively uncommon and often involve other complicating factors. [4]

The kidneys are actually discussed more often than the liver with creatine because creatine naturally breaks down into a substance called **creatinine**, which is measured on routine lab work. This can sometimes slightly elevate creatinine blood levels without necessarily indicating kidney damage. [1,4]

A Functional Nutrition Perspective

From a functional nutrition perspective, creatine is not simply a “muscle supplement.” It is part of the body’s broader cellular energy system. Muscles, nerves, balance reactions, movement, and even the brain require enormous amounts of energy to function properly.

Creatine also works best when combined with healthy lifestyle habits including:

- adequate protein intake,
- strength or resistance training,
- hydration,
- sleep,
- mineral balance,
- and blood sugar regulation.

(Get this... Creatine is not magic fairy dust in a tub. If somebody is living on donuts, soda, and late-night drive-thru biscuits and gravy while never moving their body... the creatine probably is not going to perform miracles!)

Most research continues to support simple creatine monohydrate as the most studied and effective form. Fancy “super-duper ultra-mega” versions have not consistently outperformed the basic product in research studies. [1]

Final Thoughts

Healthy aging is not just about living longer — it is about maintaining strength, stability, mobility, confidence, and independence. Creatine is not required for good health, but for some people, particularly aging adults engaged in exercise and strength training, it may offer



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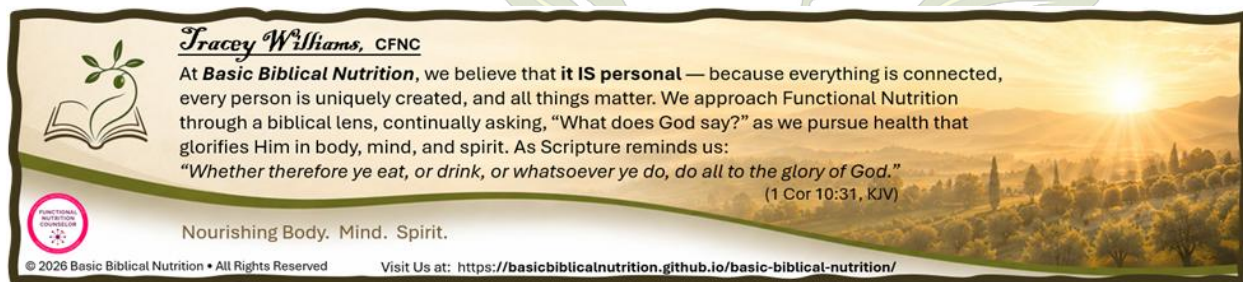
supportive benefits for muscle and functional health when used appropriately. As always, supplements should support a healthy lifestyle — not replace one.

Reference material available upon request.

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Tracey Williams is not a medical doctor. She is a Certified Functional Nutrition Counselor/Researcher. Tracey Williams does not diagnose or treat any medical illness or condition.



 **Tracey Williams, CFNC**
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(1 Cor 10:31, KJV)

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